

No Remorse, No Regret

A single drop of blood fell from the pipette into the little tray of the microscope. The air in the lab was cold and still. Only the steady whirr of machinery could be heard through the deafening silence.

A relatively short figure stood in front of the lab table. The middle-aged man supported a buzz cut and small, sharp eyes. Now, his gaze was settled on the blood in the tray. His gloved hand expertly adjusted the settings, magnifying the droplets. Each little red dot turned into thousands of blood cells.

The man seemed unnaturally absorbed in what he saw under that microscope. He leaned onto the lab table, adjusting the settings a bit more. Consumed in his project, the individual failed to notice the second character that had entered the room.

“Dr. Zhang Wei! How’s the project going?”

Zhang flinched and spun around, startled out of his reverie. A test tube tumbled off the table, but the scientist leaned down and caught it just in time.

“Ms. Dre, as much as I appreciate you coming to check on me, please do give me a bit more warning before barging into my lab.” Dr. Zhang said, straightening as he rubbed his temples.

“Sorry,” she said, smiling sheepishly. “Didn’t mean to scare you. Boss just wants an update.”

“I will hand in my report when I’m finished.”

“And how long will that be? The victim’s family members are starting to get impatient. You know Boss values customer service.”

“Yes, I know. Trust me, I will have the assailant identified soon enough. You can tell Boss that I believe I might be close to a breakthrough.”

“Alright. Thanks, Zhang! See you later!” said the young nurse.

The door swung shut as she left. Dr. Wei took a deep breath and returned to his blood analysis. He picked up a cotton swab and dabbed it in the blood. Taking his sample, he moved to examine the cells.

Carefully, he added his *Proteinase K*, which is a chemical that separates the DNA from the rest of the sample. The scientist observed the DNA and noted down the results in his signature Five Star notebook. His scrawl was messy as he wrote down the numbers and letters. Every couple seconds, he would look back at the DNA, stop to think for a second, and then quickly jot down something.

After he was done, he grabbed his notebook and strode to the other side of the lab. Dr. Zhang scanned his notes as he fell into his desk chair. As he read over the results, confusing crept across his face. His brow furrowed and his lips turned downwards in a frown. Something was wrong with the results. By no means was this possible.

The criminals DNA was all too familiar.

Being a forensic scientist that frequently found himself studying DNA, he had practically memorized his own's structure. Analyzing DNA had become a simple everyday task for him. But for a split second, the scientist doubted his own memory. How could his match up so well with the blood found on the crime scene?

Just to check, Dr. Zhang decided to carry out a paternity test. He picked up a cotton swab from the box on the lab table. He then rubbed it inside his cheek to collect a tissue sample. After,

he went to check his own DNA. Once he had finished, he sat down to compare his and the criminal's results. His confused magnified tenfold.

A match. How?

Dr. Zhang Wei thought of his wife, Mei-Ling. Back in his 20's, they had a child together. A little boy named Huang Wei. 15 years later, he ran away. Both parents and the police had searched for him far and wide. They hadn't found him.

He had disappeared without a trace.

How would Mei-Ling feel? To learn that her son was not only back, but also may be a killer? No, Doctor Wei could not tell his wife. He would not put her through that again.

Dr Zhang could not tell anyone about this.

There is a Chinese proverb that says “家丑不可外扬”. This roughly translates into “family's shames cannot be visible”. Dr. Zhang was raised in a very superstitious and cultural household. He would not bring shame to his family name.

Running his slightly wrinkly, light skinned hand through his hair, Dr. Wei sighed. He was at a crossroads. Two paths. Red pill and blue pill. Each choice equally horrible.

He could turn in his son.

Or he could deceive the victim's family, blame someone else, and inevitably land himself in prison.

Turning in his son was out of the question. There was no way he would betray his own blood. However, his son had run away. The boy had separated himself from the Wei family a long time ago. Since that day Huang decided to run away, he was no longer the scientist's child. He had given that up in exchange for the adrenaline of running away and a short-lasting feeling of freedom.

At first, when Huang had disappeared, his parents had tried to convince themselves that it was just a phase of teenage rebellion, and that he would turn up sooner or later. Naturally, they wanted to believe that their son had not abandoned them. That he had not wanted to escape. That their *own blood* didn't perceive them as dictators. It hurt, to be seen as a tyrant and a jailer to the light in their lives.

Nevertheless, the father would not betray his life's work. The forensics industry was Dr. Zhang Wei's passion. He had dedicated almost 30 years to his career. If he were to be caught committing fraud, everything he loved would be stolen in one fell swoop. His whole life would be destroyed, along with his wife's. It wasn't something he could risk.

There was no way out, no more options...

...unless he were to make his own way out.

"Detective Jacobs here. Calling to file a Missing Persons report for Zhang Wei. Age: 38, race: Taiwanese. Identifying details include black hair, brown eyes, approximately 5'8. Declared missing at 3:49 in the afternoon."

"Copy that. Thank you, Detective."

Jacobs shoved his phone in his pocket as soon as the call ended. He surveyed the empty lab. About an hour ago, the forensic company had called him with claims that one of their lead scientists were missing. After having contacted both him and his wife and receiving no answer, he stood in the lab, ready to look for clues.

First, he checked for fingerprints. He checked the cabinet handles and the beakers; he checked the test tubes and the tables; he even checked the pens and notebooks.

Not a single fingerprint in the entire lab.

There was simply no way that this was a mistake. It was virtually impossible. Dr. Zhang was reported to have been in this lab earlier this morning. His fingerprints would be on the light switch or the tables, but there was nothing. This left the detective stumped.

When Jacobs had entered the room, he had expected there to be signs of struggle. Maybe a broken beaker on the ground or a smashed window.

Once again, there had been nothing.

Now, the detective noticed that everything seemed eerily *neat*. If the scientist had been in the lab this morning, things should have been less put together. Maybe a vial out or a liquid spilled on the table.

For a second, Jacobs considered the possibility that someone had attacked him on his way home for work, but after further investigation, he realized that was not the case. He took the elevator down to the lobby to talk to the receptionist.

Leaning over the counter, he whipped out his notebook.

“Hello. My name is Detective Jacobs. Do you mind if I ask some questions?”

“Hi! Yeah, sure. What’s up?”

“Have you been here all day?”

“Yeah, I have,” she said with a laugh, “ever since 7:00 in the morning. I hate long shifts.”

“Okay. Around what time did Dr. Zhang Wei enter the building?”

“Hmm... I’d say 8:30? Not sure though.”

“Okay. Did you see him leave anytime between 11:00 and 3:00?”

“No, I didn’t. If you’re looking for him, I can take you to his lab?”

The receptionist said that she hadn’t seen Dr. Zhang leaving. He was also informed that there was no back door to the building.

“Okay, well, did you take any bathroom breaks or go anywhere since 11:00?”

“Nope! I was here the entire time.”

“Alright, thank you.” said Jacobs, finally giving up.

As he walked back to the lab, he chewed on his pen, lost in thought. This is what his notebook said: Dr. Zhang didn’t leave. There were also no fingerprints anywhere in his lab. Everything was put back in its place, neat and tidy. There were no signs of struggle. This wasn’t assault or kidnapping. That only left one more possibility.

It was intentional.

Dr. Zhang Wei, renowned forensic scientist, had disappeared without a trace.